

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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To all National Spiritual Assemblies

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Dearly loved Friends,

^{20.1} Across the globe Bahá'í communities are intently engaged

in executing the provisions of the Five Year Plan. Its opening months now behind us, there is every indication that the study of recent guidance and deliberations on the nature and extent of capacity developed thus far are bearing fruit in focused, highly

²¹ unified action at the grass roots. Principally through the efforts of homefront pioneers, in several hundred newly opened clus-

ters, the first stirrings of a program for the sustained expansion

²² and consolidation of the Faith can already be felt, while in several hundred more, further along the continuum of growth,

a pattern of rigorous activity is taking hold. Meanwhile the

friends in those clusters in the forefront of learning are gaining

²³ mastery over the dynamics that characterize rapidly expanding,

²⁴ relatively large communities.

^{20.2} In this connection, we are particularly happy to note the

degree of effort being exerted in every country to lend an added

measure of vitality to the institute process, so critical if increas-

ing numbers are to participate actively in the work required

to bring into reality a new World Order. The operation of the

²¹ institute board; the functioning of coordinators at different levels; the capabilities of friends serving as tutors of study

circles, animators of junior youth groups, teachers of children's

²² classes; and the promotion of an environment conducive at once to universal participation and mutual support and assis-

tance—nowhere is the centrality of these to the fulfillment of

the community's God-given mission lost on the friends. What

has been especially heartening to observe in this respect is the

²³ widespread mobilization of resources dedicated to the junior youth spiritual empowerment program. No less encouraging

is the zeal with which institutes have greeted the challenge of

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²⁵ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONpreparing teachers for successive grades of Bahá'í children's

classes as additional materials for this purpose have been made

available. It seems timely, then, to offer National Spiritual

Assemblies and their training institutes further guidance on the

implementation of the main sequence of courses and those that

²⁶ branch off from it.

The path of service

^{20.3} A number of years ago, to aid the believers in thinking

about the process of growth at the level of the cluster, we

²¹ introduced the concept of two complementary movements.

The progress of a steady, ever-widening stream of individuals

through the courses of the institute represents one of these. It is

not only responsible for giving impetus to the other—the devel -

opment of the cluster, discernable in the collective capacity to

manifest a pattern of life in conformity with the teachings of the

²² Faith—but also dependent on it for its own perpetuation. It was in view of mounting evidence of the effects of the Ruhi Institute

curriculum on these two mutually reinforcing movements that

we recommended its adoption worldwide six years ago. At

the time, we did not comment specifically on the pedagogical

²³ principles governing the curriculum; nevertheless, it should be apparent to the friends that the curriculum possesses desirable

characteristics, some of which have been described in broad

²⁴ terms in our messages regarding the current series of global Plans. Of particular significance is its organizing principle:

developing capacity to serve the Cause and humanity in a

process likened to walking a path of service. This conception

²⁵ shapes both content and structure.

^{20.4} The main sequence of courses is organized so as to set the

²¹ individual, whether Bahá'í or not, on a path being defined by the accumulating experience of the community in its endeavor

to open before humanity the vision of Bahá'u'lláh's World

Order. The very notion of a path is, itself, indicative of the na-

²² ture and purpose of the courses, for a path invites participation, it beckons to new horizons, it demands effort and movement, it

accommodates different paces and strides, it is structured and

²³ defined. A path can be experienced and known, not only by one or two but by scores upon scores; it belongs to the community.

To walk a path is a concept equally expressive. It requires of

the individual volition and choice; it calls for a set of skills

and abilities but also elicits certain qualities and attitudes; it

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related lines of exploration; it may seem easy at the outset but

becomes more challenging further along. And crucially, one

²⁵ walks the path in the company of others.

20.5 At present the main sequence consists of eight courses,

21 though it is understood there may eventually be as many as eighteen that will address acts of service related to such

requirements as coordination and administration, social action

and involvement in the discourses of society. There are currently

two points along the sequence at which an individual may

22 choose to follow a specialized path of service. The first appears at Book 3. From among the friends who complete it and begin

to offer a relatively simple class for children in the first grade

of a program for their spiritual education, a percentage will

want to dedicate themselves to this field of service, pursuing

23 in time a series of progressively more complex branch courses for teaching Grades 2 to 6. This does not mean that they will

abandon study of the main sequence. Indeed, courses that make

24 up a specialized path of service anticipate that participants are continuing to progress, each at a pace suitable to his or

25 her situation, along the path traced out by the main sequence.

Book 5, which seeks to raise up animators of junior youth

groups, constitutes the second point at which a series of courses

26 branch out.

20.6 Additional avenues of exploration will no doubt appear

along the main sequence in due time. Some may be of universal

interest, such as the two mentioned above, while others may

be limited to specific local needs. As with the main sequence

itself, content and structure must emerge out of continued

21 collective experience in the field, an experience that is not haphazard or subject to the forces of personal preference but is

guided by the institutions of the Faith. The generation of such

22 an experience will call for a still greater infusion of energy from a much larger portion of the population, and it would be pre-

mature, in all but a few places, for institutes to give attention to

the creation or implementation of other branch courses at this

23 juncture in the unfoldment of the current series of global Plans.

Coordination

20.7 Clearly, the approach to capacity building described above

21 represents an attempt to achieve a certain dynamics within a population that brings together service and the generation of

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23 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONknowledge and its diffusion, a subject which we discussed,

albeit briefly, in our Rid .ván 2010 message. Here we address a

24 few practical considerations, which the emergence of the two aforementioned specialized paths of service has made all the

25 more relevant.

20.8 At any given moment it is possible to view from one of two

perspectives what occurs in a cluster as the pattern of action

promoted by the Five Year Plan, through which is woven the

fabric of a vibrant community life, gathers in strength. Both

perspectives are equally valid; each offers a particular way of

thinking and speaking about what is taking place. From one

21 perspective an educational process with three distinct stages appears in sharp relief: the first for the youngest members of the

community, the second for those in the challenging transitional

years, and the third for youth and adults. In this context, one

speaks of three educational imperatives, each distinguished

22 by its own methods and materials, each claiming a share of resources, and each served by mechanisms to systematize

experience and to generate knowledge based on insights gained

23 in the field. Quite naturally, then, three discussions take shape around the implementation of the program for the spiritual

education of children, the junior youth spiritual empowerment

24 program, and the main sequence of courses.

20.9 From another perspective one thinks in terms of the three-

month cycles of activity through which a community grows—

21 the burst of expansion experienced as a result of intense action;

the necessary period of consolidation during which increases

in ranks are fortified as they, for example, participate in

22 devotional gatherings and the Nineteen Day Feast and receive visits at their homes;
and the opportunities designated for all

to reflect and plan. The question of teaching among receptive

23 populations moves to the foreground in this light, and the challenge of seeking out
souls who are willing to engage in a

conversation about the world around them and participate in a

24 collective effort to transform it comes into focus.

20.10 It is especially at the level of coordination that it proves

indispensable to step back and view from these two vantage

21 points what is essentially one reality. Doing so makes it possible to analyze
accurately, to assess strategically, to allocate

wisely, and to avoid fragmentation. At this point, then, early

22 in the execution of the Plan, it seems more vital than ever for attention to be devoted
to the issue of coordination. Though

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already well understood, the form it should assume under

diverse circumstances is in need of articulation. We have asked

the International Teaching Centre to follow efforts made in this

direction, particularly in the several hundred furthest advanced

24 clusters worldwide, in order to effect the rapid systematization of lessons learned.

20.11 In all such clusters, where the demands of large-scale

growth are asserting themselves, each stage of the educational

process promoted by the training institute must receive added

support. The work of the coordinator should be reinforced by

21 assistance from a growing number of experienced individuals,

²² and meetings for the exchange of information and insights become regular and more systematic in approach. So, too,

must periodic occasions be created for the three coordinators

²³ appointed by the institute—or, where applicable, teams of coordinators concerned with study circles, junior youth groups

and children's classes respectively—to examine together the

strength of the educational process as a whole. And they, in

turn, should meet on a regular basis with the Area Teaching

²⁴ Committee. Further, if an adequate flow of information, guidance and much-needed funds is to reach the cluster, a parallel

set of steps will have to be taken by the board of the institute

²⁵ to enhance the functioning of that agency at the regional level. Where such a mature scheme of coordination is brought into

place, the Auxiliary Board members and their assistants will

be able to provide support across all areas of action with even

²⁶ greater effectiveness.

^{20.12} One final point merits reflection in this respect. Nearly all

of the several hundred clusters under consideration are associated

with one or another of some forty sites for the dissemination

of learning established by the Office of Social and Economic

Development at the World Centre in response to the over-

whelming demand for the junior youth program experienced

throughout the world. Institutes operating in these clusters have

already benefited over the past year from knowledge gained

²¹ through the sites, particularly in relation to coordination of the program. Without question, the capacity to sustain scores of

junior youth groups lent a powerful impetus to the progress of

all such clusters and contributed decisively to the subsequent

development of study circles and children's classes. Sites sup-

ported by the Office of Social and Economic Development will

23 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONcontinue to assist training institutes in addressing
the complex

set of questions arising out of the implementation of a program

24 for an age group whose enormous potential must remain the object of ongoing
exploration. We look to the institutes

25 themselves, however, to foster the learning process necessary to manage large
numbers of children's classes and study circles, to put in place a scheme at the cluster level
that will strengthen

coordination across their three defined areas of action, and

26 to open the flow of resources from the regional level into the grass roots—this, to
ensure the seamless progression of sizable

contingents from one stage of the educational process to the

next and to facilitate the steady unfoldment of cycles of activity

27 so essential to systematic growth.

Classes for children

20.13 Among the range of questions now before every training

21 institute one stands out as particularly pressing: how to mobi-lize sufficient numbers
of children's class teachers for successive

grades and, by extension, tutors who can form groups to study

the requisite courses. The units that comprise the three books

22 currently available contain both materials for study by teachers and lessons for
children, allowing institutes to establish without

delay the first three grades of a six-year program. To raise up an

23 initial corps of teachers for these grades, they may well have to employ temporary
measures. A good scheme of coordination,

24 built incrementally in keeping with demands on the ground,

should make it possible to respond to exigencies with a degree

of flexibility while maintaining the integrity of the overall

25 educational process in the long term.

20.14 Besides the systematic training of teachers for successive

grades, institutes will need to learn about the formation of

21 classes for distinct age groups in villages and neighborhoods;

the provision of teachers for various classes; the retention of

students year after year, grade after grade; and the continued

22 progress of children from a wide variety of households and backgrounds—in short,
the establishment of an expanding,

sustainable system for child education that will keep pace with

23 both the growing concern among parents for their youngsters to develop sound
moral structures and the rise in human re-

sources in the community. The task, while immense, is relatively

24 straightforward, and we urge institutes everywhere to give it the attention which it so
clearly deserves, focusing especially on the

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membering that the quality of the teaching-learning experience

26 depends, to a great extent, on the capabilities of the teacher.

20.15 A word of caution seems to be in order. It is certainly not

21 incorrect to speak of “training” children’s class teachers or, for that matter, animators
of junior youth groups. Institutes,

22 however, ought to take care, lest they begin to perceive their work as training in
techniques, losing sight of the conception

of capacity building at the heart of the institute process that

23 entails a profound understanding of Bahá’u’lláh’s Revelation.

Educational materials

20.16 In light of the foregoing paragraphs, the question of educa-

tional materials specifically as they pertain to children’s classes

and to junior youth groups has to be considered. With regard to

the former, we explained in our Rid .ván 2010 message that the

21 lessons prepared by the Ruhi Institute would constitute the core of a program for the
spiritual education of children, around which secondary elements could be organized.
Whether or not

any additional elements are required to reinforce the educa-

22 tional process for each grade would generally be determined by teachers themselves,
on the basis of specific circumstances, not

infrequently in consultation with the institute coordinator at

23 the cluster level. It is assumed that, if found to be appropriate,

any additional items would be selected from resources readily

24 available. There will seldom be cause to formalize the use of such items, whether directly through their adoption by training

institutes or indirectly through their widespread systematic

25 promotion.

20.17 In the case of junior youth groups, a similar approach is

21 encouraged by the Office of Social and Economic Development.

The core of the program consists of a series of textbooks

studied by the groups. We understand that, at present, seven

of a projected eighteen textbooks, exploring a range of themes

22 from a Bahá'í perspective, though not in the mode of religious instruction, are available. These form the major component of

23 a three-year program. Another nine textbooks will provide a distinctly Bahá'í component, and two of these are currently in use. Animators are advised to complement study with artistic

24 activities and service projects. As with children's class teachers,

the institute coordinator at the cluster level can offer animators

25 assistance in determining how to proceed. Yet, most often,

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27 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONsuch projects and activities are selected by the junior youth

28 themselves, in light of their own circumstances and inclinations,

29 in consultation with the group's animator.

20.18 In all such matters, those serving as teachers and animators

21 alike are called upon to exercise discretion. Education is a vast field, and educational theories abound. Surely many have

22 considerable merit, but it should be remembered that none is free of assumptions about the nature of the human being and

society. An educational process should, for example, create in a

23 child awareness of his or her potentialities, but the glorification of self has to be scrupulously avoided. So often in the name of

building confidence the ego is bolstered. Similarly, play has its

24 place in the education of the young. Children and junior youth,

however, have proven time and again their capacity to engage

25 in discussions on abstract subjects, undertaken at a level appropriate to their age, and derive great joy from the serious pursuit

of understanding. An educational process that dilutes content

26 in a mesmerizing sea of entertainment does them no service. We trust that, in studying the institute courses, teachers and

animators will find themselves increasingly equipped to make

judicious decisions in selecting any materials or activities

necessary, whether from traditional educational sources or from

27 the wealth of items, such as songs, stories, and games, that are sure to be developed for the young in the Bahá'í community in

28 the years to come.

20.19 Propelled by forces generated both within and outside the

21 Bahá'í community, the peoples of the earth can be seen to be moving from divergent directions, closer and closer to one

another, towards what will be a world civilization so stupen-

dous in character that it would be futile for us to attempt to

22 imagine it today. As this centripetal movement of populations accelerates across the globe, some elements in every culture,

not in accord with the teachings of the Faith, will gradually fall

23 away, while others will be reinforced. By the same token, new elements of culture will evolve over time as people hailing from

24 every human group, inspired by the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh,

give expression to patterns of thought and action engendered

25 by His teachings, in part through artistic and literary works.

26 It is with such considerations in mind that we welcome the decision of the Ruhi Institute, in formulating its courses, to

leave for the friends to address locally issues related to artistic

activity. What we ask at this stage, then, when energies are to be

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groups, is that the multiplication of supplementary items for this purpose be allowed to occur naturally, as an outgrowth of the process of community building gathering momentum in villages and neighborhoods. We long to see, for instance, the

28 emergence of captivating songs from every part of the world, in every language, that will impress upon the consciousness

of the young the profound concepts enshrined in the Bahá'í

29 teachings. Yet such an efflorescence of creative thought will fail to materialize, should the friends fall, however inadvertently,

into patterns prevalent in the world that give license to those

with financial resources to impose their cultural perspective on

others, inundating them with materials and products aggres-

30 sively promoted. Further, every effort should be made to protect spiritual education from the perils of commercialization. The

Ruhi Institute itself has explicitly discouraged the proliferation

of products and items that treat its identity as a brand to be

marketed. We hope that the friends will respect its diligence in

31 this matter.

20.20 In this connection, it gives us pleasure to inform you that

21 we have created an International Advisory Board to assist the Ruhi Institute in overseeing its system for the preparation, pro-

duction, and distribution of materials, the content and structure

of which now draw extensively on Bahá'í experience worldwide

22 in applying the teachings and principles of the Faith to the life of humanity. As it gradually takes up its work, the Board will

be able to respond to related issues and follow the development

23 of supplementary materials that are aligned with the direction set by the global Plans.

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20.21 In closing, we feel compelled to address a few words to

training institutes throughout the world: It should be remem-

**bered that the Bahá'í children's class teacher and the junior
youth group animator, entrusted with so much responsibility for
strengthening the moral foundations of the community, will, in**

²¹ most places, be a young person in his or her teens. Increasingly these young people
will emerge, it can be expected, from the

junior youth spiritual empowerment program imbued with a

²² strong twofold purpose, both to develop their inherent poten-tialities and to
contribute to the transformation of society. But

they may also come from any one of a number of educational

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²⁴ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONbackgrounds with all the hope in their hearts that,
through

strenuous concerted effort, the world will change. Irrespective of

particulars, they will, one and all, share in the desire to dedicate

their time and energy, talents and abilities, to service to their

communities. Many, when given the opportunity, will gladly

²⁵ devote a few years of their lives to the provision of spiritual education to the rising
generations. In the young people of the

world, then, lies a reservoir of capacity to transform society

²⁶ waiting to be tapped. And the release of this capacity should be regarded by every
institute as a sacred charge.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]